post.[8] That Loraine was cousin to Lancelot Oliphant, the head of the Eastern Department in the Foreign Office, no doubt helped his position.[9]

Furthermore, although he differed in the policy he believed Britain should be pursuing in Persia, Loraine appeared to be attuned to Curzon's thinking. In August 1922, for example, Loraine wrote to the foreign secretary giving his impression of the entire Persian situation, which he summed up in an allegorical story. In this tale, Britain and Russia are cast as competitive beaus, vying for the position as the paramount love of Persia – a fickle woman happy to play her courtiers off against each other. Loraine characterises 'John Bull's' downfall as insisting on giving 'tiresome lectures and good advice' to 'Miss P.', when all the latter wants 'is that he should pay, and take charge again of the household expenses as well as giving handsome pin-money. Then, so long as some rather nominal appearances are kept up, he can do what he likes with the house'.

Of course, the allegory of 'Miss P.' and 'John Bull' entirely over-simplifies the relationship between Britain and Persia. It also conveniently lays the blame for Britain's current troubles with Persia solely at the door of the latter – for it is 'John Bull' who is trying to do the best for 'Miss P.', while she is simply disloyal and petulant. Yet this idea that Britain was being something of a martyr, suffering as it was for having tried to better things for Persia, appealed to the likes of Curzon. It was easier to believe this than admit that the Persian policy which he and his allies had pursued since 1918 had failed because of a fundamental misjudgement of the Persian situation. Even by 1922 Curzon still refused to recognise that he had made a miscalculation with the Anglo-Persian Agreement. Writing to Loraine in May 1922 Curzon insisted that it had been the Cabinet's decision to withdraw Britain's troops together with the ungratefulness of the Persian people which had led to the failure of his Persian schemes.[10] As the self-proclaimed expert on Persia, Curzon was, of course, above reproach himself.

Together with being able to get on well with the foreign secretary, Loraine was also very much the right man at the right time. From the outset of his arrival in Tehran the new ambassador was to follow a policy of studied aloofness from Persia's political turmoil. In Loraine's opinion, the Persian